Above the Snow Melt

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The New Curator

COL-307301

Assistant Curator: Good morning, everyone! On behalf of the Laplace Museum, I'd like to welcome you to the "Snowy Mountain Ecology" exhibition!

Assistant Curator: Make sure to head over to the main entrance hall in ten minutes for our opening ceremony.

Assistant Curator: As part of the ceremony, our new museum director, Mr. Ezra, will have a speech.

The crowd shuffled toward the entrance of the exhibition hall.

X: Funny running into you here.

Quite the unexpected meeting.

Medicine Pocket: Oh, you're... that guy with the initial for a name—what was it again?

Mesmer Jr.: This is X. You ought to get to know your colleagues, Medicine Pocket.

Medicine Pocket: It's not my job to socialize; X is an unknown, something to be unraveled, not remembered—

X: .....

X: Let's just focus on the exhibition. It's our new colleague's first project.

X: He climbed a mountain solo, gathered all the exhibit items, and provided his own annotations, all without help from the Laplace Field Team.

X: That's no easy feat... He must have put in serious effort.

Mesmer Jr.: I recommended he bring more people.

Mesmer Jr.: But... still he went alone.

Mesmer Jr.: Aside from our tools and equipment, he had no other resources.

X: So, Ezra reached out to you—I suppose you wouldn't have shown up at such an "arcanist" gathering otherwise.

Medicine Pocket: Well, well, seems our little mushroom got some help; he wasn't "alone" after all.

Medicine Pocket: What did he ask you for?

X: He needed a weapon, something subtle, flexible, and with a bit of humor.

X: And I happened to have such a weapon.

Medicine Pocket: Get to the point.

X: I gave him a "gun" ... of sorts.

Medicine Pocket: Ha! I suppose it's some kind of wacky gun with a twisted barrel!

The conversation was cut off by a sudden commotion, and the young researchers turned to the podium.

Assistant Curator: Did you say... Director Ezra, he ...

The assistant who announced the director's speech grew pale and whispered into the intercom.

Then, maintaining composure, she turned to the audience.

Assistant Curator: I apologize for the inconvenience; Director Ezra's speech has unfortunately been postponed until three hours from now.

Assistant Curator: However, the exhibition opening will continue as planned. Feel free to explore.

This was supposed to be his moment.

Mesmer Jr.: He is late?

Mesmer Jr. frowned as the assistant rushed off backstage.

X: This isn't good. First impressions matter in social interactions. And from what I know of Ezra, he cares about these things.

Medicine Pocket: Well, I think it could all turn out to be a blessing in disguise.

Medicine Pocket: Who remembers a speech delivered on time? A late director will be much more memorable than a punctual one.

X: He doesn't need any gimmicks.

X: His exhibits are all excellent, enough to make everyone remember the new director of the Laplace Museum. Look over there!

X pointed to the other end of the display case, where two staff members in gray-white uniforms stood in front of the glass showcase.

One of them was pressed against the glass, nose almost touching it.

Laplace Staff I: I've never seen a Rutile nugget this big.

Laplace Staff I: Mr. Ryan usually exhibits specimens from the botanical garden—but this... this is the real deal!

Laplace Staff II: This new director seems to have some fresh ideas. Have you met him?

Laplace Staff I: No, nearly as soon as he came from the Australia branch, he set off to the snowy mountains. Not many people have seen him.

Laplace Staff I: But everyone's curious why he chose this theme. His previous research was on endemic fungi in Australia, this seems completely unrelated ...

Laplace Staff II: Well, now he's starting to impress me.

Laplace Staff II: An amateur researcher in search of minerals, on a solo mission to a snow-capped mountain—sounds like the beginning of a pulp adventure.

Shifting their gaze, the young researcher nodded in satisfaction.

X: See? Everyone's enthralled by him!

Mesmer Jr.: .....

X: What's wrong, Mesmer?

Mesmer Jr.: Oh, it's nothing. I was just thinking—he really did it.

Mesmer Jr.: I never thought he would succeed.

5#1

Change of the Coils

COL-307302

Ezra: Hello, I'm here to check in. I made a reservation over the phone a couple of days ago.

Assistant Curator: Mr. Theodore, right?

Ezra: Call me Ezra.

Assistant Curator: Go straight down the corridor, and you'll find the room at the end on your right. The director has been waiting for quite some time.

Office, Laplace

Director Ryan: Hello, young man.

Ezra: Hello, Dr. Ryan.

Director Ryan: I've read of the impressive things you've accomplished in the papers, from the "Reincarnator" to the Uluru Games.

Director Ryan: This is something most humans cannot achieve. I believe you're qualified to be the curator of the Laplace Museum.

Ezra: Thank you for your confidence, doctor.

Ezra: But... I'm not sure I'm ready. I'm only a researcher; I don't have any experience in management...

Director Ryan: Don't worry, my boy.

Dr. Ryan stepped out from behind the desk and led Ezra to a bookshelf.

Director Ryan: From the first row here to the last volume at the end of the shelf—these will be all the experience you need.

Ezra: ... Notes on management?

Director Ryan: Yes, precisely. Every note taken from the very first day of the Laplace Museum until this very day is kept here.

Director Ryan: You'll have plenty of time to dive into them, get familiar, and gain that experience—but not right now.

Director Ryan: Now, you must put into practice on your own.

Ezra: ... So, I'm to take charge of holding an exhibition, right? I caught wind of it through the Laplace liaison.

Director Ryan: Exactly that, my boy.

Director Ryan: You might organize an exhibition focused on your Australian fungi or perhaps bring that long-researched story on the "Reincarnator" into the spotlight. Both very worthy of showcasing.

Ezra: No, Dr. Ryan, not those.

The young man shook his head slowly but firmly. Then set about expressing his own idea.

Ezra: I want to put together an exhibition centered around "The Ecology of Snowy Alpine Mountains."

Director Ryan: Snow mountain?

That's somewhat unexpected.

Ezra: Snowy mountains, yes.

Ezra: I intend to climb the Alps—the Matterhorn, to be precise—from the north, collecting plants and minerals to bring back to the museum for display.

Ezra had made a checklist; he came prepared.

Ezra: I've got here an itinerary, a distribution of exhibit items to be found in the Alps, and a climate comparison for this month with previous years. Take a look.

Director Ryan: Hmm...

Director Ryan: This is a worthwhile plan. You've thought through the potential dangers and avoided the trickiest approaches; it all seems feasible. But... why?

Ezra: I don't understand. What do you mean by "why?"

Director Ryan: Why pick "The Ecology of Snow-Capped Alpine Mountains" as your exhibition's theme?

Director Ryan: You've spent years on Australian fungi and a gripping story in the "Reincarnator.". Why would you propose this instead?

Ezra: Director Ryan, I know how I've been portrayed in academic journals and other written sources —the mycologist from Australia.

Ezra: I'm happy to share my mycology research with my colleagues to show off the results of my years of work.

Ezra: But this time is different. My choice of exhibition theme holds a special meaning to me.

Ezra: Trust me, my decision to go with the "Snowy Mountains" theme was carefully considered.

Director Ryan: ……

Director Ryan: As director of the Laplace Museum, I wouldn't recommend taking on such a challenge for your first step.

Director Ryan: But… my time in that role has already passed.

Director Ryan: The decision-making power for your exhibit lies in your hands now.

Director Ryan: The young take risks, revel in adventures, and we need that boldness.

Director Ryan: As for an old gentleman like me, risks lie in my past. Ahead, a peaceful life and quality time with my granddaughter.

Mesmer Jr.: ……

Mesmer Jr. stood outside the office door, clasping her hands together, taking deep breaths as if trying to calm herself.

Mesmer Jr.: Don't worry, it's all done now… You can finally relax.

Mesmer Jr.: ……!

An unexpected visitor entered.

Ezra: Oh, sorry. Did I startle you?

Mesmer Jr.: Why are you here? And who brought you?

Ezra: Another Laplace researcher. They told me I could wait for you to finish your work here…

Mesmer Jr.: If you wanted a consultation on Artificial Somnambulism, you should have gone through the proper registration process and waited for your appointment … rather than slinking into my office without a word.

She stood in the corner, not budging an inch. Around her hung an air of sharpness accented by disinfectant.

But Ezra was accustomed to diffusing tense situations.

Ezra: Apologies for my abruptness, Miss Mesmer Jr.

Ezra: I'm Ezra, the new director of the Laplace Museum. I've been waiting for the chance to ask for a favor.

Mesmer Jr.: Ezra…? I think I've heard that name before…

Mesmer Jr.: Yeah… "Ezra of the Uluru Games." I've read about you in the reports. A mycology researcher, and… a pure-blooded human?

Ezra: You've got me.

The girl nodded cautiously where she stood.

Ezra: Sorry, did I disturb you? If you would like, I can provide emotional reassurance and counseling.

Ezra: I did this sort of thing back at the Australian branch. I'm here to help, if you're open to it.

Mesmer Jr.: No, no ... I'm fine. Don't worry about me.

Her stance relaxed a bit, and she moved to the sofa before taking a seat in the corner.

Mesmer Jr.: So, what's this favor?

Mesmer Jr.: I'm afraid I don't know much about managing museums, nor planning exhibitions... I'm not sure how I could be of much use to you.

Ezra: Ah, no ... Miss Mesmer Jr., I'm actually seeking your expertise in "magnetism," or more specifically, the "magnetic field".

Ezra took off his backpack and pulled out a divining rod.

Ezra: This is my divining rod. Thanks to Laplace's tech, it can sense the magnetic fields of organisms and fungi nearby and guide me to traces of their activity.

Ezra: It's been my trusty sidekick through rainforests, reefs, and valleys.

Ezra: But I've found that in high-altitude, its accuracy starts to drop, making my work more challenging.

Ezra: I thought dear you might help me figure this out?

Mesmer Jr.: I'll do my best.

Mesmer Jr. extended her left hand, waving her electrically calibrated glove beneath the divining rod.

On the edge where her glove met the cuff, there was a small red scratch clearly visible.

Mesmer Jr.: ...The wavelength diagram looks complete.

Mesmer Jr.: Now, let's change the parameters to simulate low-pressure conditions... Hmmm- Yeah, you were right. Malfunctions might occur during changes in altitude.

Mesmer Jr.: .....

Mesmer Jr.: It's not a serious issue; a simple magnetic field enchantment would properly calibrate it.

Mesmer Jr.: I can contact Evan from Laplace's Laboratory No. 2 to sort this out for you.

Mesmer Jr.: ...Ezra, are you listening?

Ezra: I... I am! Sorry, I got a bit distracted...

As if a student called on by the teacher, the boy straightened up, refocusing his attention.

Ezra: Will the enchantment be stable if I were to climb further, say to ultra-high altitudes, above 3,500 meters?

Mesmer Jr.: Ultra-high altitudes? Where are you planning to go?

Ezra: The Matterhorn.

Mesmer Jr.: You're climbing ... the Matterhorn?

Ezra: Yes, I'm aiming to collect specimens needed for the upcoming exhibition.

Mesmer Jr.: That... isn't a wise plan, Ezra. I know humans have stronger physical endurance than arcanists, but...

Mesmer Jr.: ... So many foreseeable risks; altitude sickness, snowstorms, avalanches, native beasts, or critters ...

Mesmer Jr. tugged at her sleeve, her hands itching.

Ezra: Yes, the journey will undoubtedly be very challenging.

In contrast, the boy had a calm and determined demeanor.

Ezra: That's why I came to seek your help. I must be prepared for everything to make this "crazy" plan a reality.

Ezra: It's worth the risk for me.

Mesmer Jr.: Then no one can stop you... You're determined to climb that mountain... right?

Mesmer Jr.: I have a hard time understanding people like you ... risk-seekers ... But, I can't stop you.

She lowered her head, taking a deep breath.

Mesmer Jr.: ...During the journey, if you're lucky enough, you might find a deep red, reflective metallic vein in the granite bodies on both sides of the mountain ridge.

Mesmer Jr.: That's Rutile, natural titanium dioxide. Once processed its surface can enhance its sensors, solving the thorny problem you face.

Mesmer Jr.: With it, the sensing range of the divining rod will be significantly expanded, even capable of penetrating thick snow cover and complex rock layers.

Mesmer Jr.: It will be your guiding star in finding those rare specimens.

Ezra left, and Mesmer Jr. turned off the lights in the room after him.

There in the darkness, she stared at the sickbed, as if examining an invisible patient.

Mesmer Jr.: Quiet down, ok? Stop talking or laughing.

She shook her head forcefully, as if attempting to throw off some tainted mark.

Mesmer Jr.: Where did I put the disinfectant?

5#1

Circe's Plant

COL-307303

Mesmer Jr.: He found the Rutile?

Mesmer Jr.: ...Alright, I understand. Prepare the remaining materials to enhance the divining rod for him. Is he still with you?

Mesmer Jr.: Not anymore? Where could he have gone—

Ezra: Phew... Excuse me, Miss Mesmer Jr.!

Mesmer Jr.: ……

Mesmer Jr.: Here, have some hot water, and this is a blanket, wrap yourself in it.

The boy, disheveled and with reddened cheeks from the cold, stumbled in.

Ezra: Oh... Thank you...

Mesmer Jr.: Climbing a mountain is far from a walk in the park, you know.

Mesmer Jr.: But congratulations on your success. The Rutile sample you've provided is excellent in size and purity; just a small piece will strengthen your divining rod.

Ezra: Yes, I got lucky.

Ezra held the hot water, his smiling face obscured by steam.

Ezra: And I found this—

Mesmer Jr.: What is this ...?

Ezra: Mandrake, also known as a Mandrake Root or Circe's Plant in some places.

Ezra: It's a standard 12 inches, with oval leaves and bell-shaped white flowers. I deliberately kept some of its leaves.

Ezra: Since the Middle Ages, arcanists have used Mandrake leaves to craft soothing teas, a gentler and safer practice than consuming its roots. It has a long history...

Mesmer Jr.: An interesting tale, but I don't understand why you've brought it to me.

Mesmer Jr.: ...Perhaps it could be useful for your snowy mountain ecology exhibition, but my Artificial Somnambulism patients have no need for Mandrake hallucinogens.

A self-deprecating smile appeared on Mesmer's face, her sense of humor always a little offbeat.

Ezra: Yes, it could be a good exhibit item.

Ezra: I'll set up a spot for it in the exhibition hall, prepare the soil, and use calming sprays to keep it from waking up halfway through the exhibition and emitting its piercing screams...

Ezra: But before that, I'd thought I might leave half of its leaves for you, Miss Mesmer.

His face beamed like a flower in sunlight.

Mesmer Jr.: I don't need these.
I'm not a plant researcher, nor am I in the hobby of collecting such specimens.

Mesmer Jr. looked at the Mandrake cluster.

Mesmer Jr.: And frankly ... it's ugly.

Ezra: Ugly ...?

Ezra widened his eyes with shock.

Ezra: I think Mandrakes are one of the cuter types of plants used in potions...!

Ezra: They have a human shape, and people often prefer things that are "humanesque;" like... dolls or the subjects of paintings...

Somewhat embarrassed, he fumbled the Mandrake on the table back into his pocket.

Mesmer Jr.: ...You have peculiar tastes.

Mesmer Jr. placed her hands on her knees, taking a deep breath.

Mesmer Jr.: So, you put down the Rutile, and rushed half-frozen into my office without looking back, all to show me this Mandrake?

Ezra: Yes.

Mesmer Jr.: .....

Mesmer having exhausted her questions, fell silent, unwilling to speak further on the matter.

Whenever two intelligent people stumble over a subject for too long without finding agreement, it's usually best discarded.

Ezra: I just wanted to give you... an option.

It was a concession.

Ezra: The option to take it.

Ezra: But I understand... You don't need it for now, at least. Still, if you change your mind—please let me know.

Ezra stood up shakily, looking at his wristwatch.

Ezra: I gotta go now. I have another meeting with some colleagues... Phew...!

Mesmer Jr.: Be careful.

Mesmer Jr.: Your body is still weak... You should rest a bit more.

Ezra: I... I'm fine. Just a bit tired... Don't worry about me.

Ezra shook his head once and then shook it again, almost to convince himself.

Ezra: There's not much time left to prepare for the exhibition. I have to make the most of every moment.

He stood up once again, much more carefully this time, his movements slow and deliberate.

Glancing back at the door, Ezra bowed slightly and then bid farewell.

Ezra: Thank you for your help, Miss Mesmer Jr.

Ezra: Without your guidance, my journey would have been much more difficult, and perhaps I would have been unable to successfully detect the plants I need.

Ezra: You have been the driving force behind the Snowy Mountain Ecology Exhibition.

Ezra: Later in the evening, I'll have my assistant send over tickets to the exhibition.

Receptionist: Dr. Mesmer, there is a package for you to sign for.

Mesmer Jr.: A package? Where is it from?

Receptionist: It was received by the front desk just after Director Ezra left. He asked me to deliver it to you.

Mesmer Jr.: I'll pick it up later.

The package was light, containing two tubes of pale yellow hand cream in aluminum packaging, along with a note.

"The hand cream is made from honey in Sydney."

I noticed some wounds on your wrists; moisturizing them could help with healing. I don't know much when it comes to skincare products, but I hope you don't mind the scent.

"Yours sincerely, Ezra."

5#1

Sailor of the World

COL-307304

X: Ezra's a thoughtful kid; he seems to really care about you.

X: In case you didn't realize—let me point it out—he's worried about your anxiety and notices everything about you.

Mesmer Jr.: Just because I have to deal with crazy people doesn't mean I'm one of them.

Mesmer Jr.: If you had half of Ezra's ability to read people, you might understand my reluctance about this.

X: I wouldn't turn him down if I were you.

X shifted his posture slightly, his gaze moving to a display case in the distance.

Surrounded by companion plants, a cluster of white-flowered white dryads, or Dryas octopetala as it was labelled, was in full bloom.

X: It might sound a bit iffy, but if some young kid dragged themselves weather-beaten and food-poisoned to me just to find a way to ease my stress, I'd be more appreciative.

Mesmer Jr.: Food poisoned?

X: From what I heard, he got caught in a blizzard while hunting for those Mandrakes.

X: To stay warm, our mycologist had to eat slices of Trichoderma cornu-damae from the Australian desert. Soon after, he developed a feverish spike in body temperature.

X: It was his way of playing it safe, and it worked out—he braved the blizzard and unearthed that gorgeous Mandrake.

Mesmer Jr.: ...So that's why he seemed so weak. I should've guessed;

X: Don't fret too much; he knows how to take care of himself.

X: After the blizzard cleared, he immediately downed some Red-Flower Prickly Pear juice, to clear out the mushroom's toxins before they could do real damage.

X: By the time he showed up at my door, he was halfway recovered from the poisoning.

Medicine Pocket: And then you two got into all that talk about... "guns" and such?

X: Technically, it wasn't really a gun.

X: But it did shoot a kind of bullet, like little seeds or balls of steel or crystal.

X: Got it. It must've ticked all your boxes and left you feeling pleased.

Ezra: This is... a slingshot?

X: Exactly, it's called the "Air-Compressed Spring Slingshot."

X: You see, it's compact and lightweight, and you don't need any fancy Arcane Skill to use it. The Rube Goldberg inside the copper tube handle does all the work for you.

X pulled back the slingshot, and the small spring spanning across the rubber ducky emitted a soft hum, ready to unleash a chunk of butter.

X: All you have to do is aim and release. It's that simple.

X: The slingshot's bullets come in different flavors, ranging from electric zaps to tiny blasts, scatter shots, and piercing rounds.

X: As long as your aim isn't dreadful, you'll be more or less safe from any mountain critters.

Ezra: I never thought a slingshot could be so powerful...

X: Welcome to the LSCC（Laplace Scientific Computing Center） headquarters, where even a shoe sole can hide a foldable explosive.

X: ...But, from what I've heard, the Australian branch is even wilder than here.

Ezra: Well, you could say that.

Ezra lounged back on the couch, next to him a steaming cup of tea.

He took a careful sip, then winced as it burned his tongue.

Ezra: Phew... But I'm not part of the research department. Technically, I'm a microbiologist, not an inventor...

Ezra: And... I'm sorry I didn't explain what I needed, Mr. X.

Ezra shuffled in his seat, searching out a comfortable position, before straightening up a bit.

Ezra: I don't need lethal weapons.

X: But you do need something to scare off any mountain beasts.

Ezra: Yes... I suppose I just need to make them go away for a while. That should do it.

X: They might follow you, you know. Beasts can be persistent when protecting their territory.

Ezra: I only need them to leave me alone, just for a little while.

Ezra: I wouldn't like to kill them or maim them.

Ezra: You know, I'm planning an exhibition about snowy mountain ecology.

Ezra: ...If I harmed any local wildlife for this exhibition or disrupted their natural ecosystem, it would defeat the purpose.

X: Oh... Okay ...

X sighed, taking a seat.

X: The reports and rumors are true, you really are an incredibly kind kid.

He tossed the magazine onto the couch and pulled out a square plastic bag from his jacket pocket.

X: Take this; you won't need bullets anymore.

Ezra: What is this ...?

Ezra: ...The Little Gardener: Bellflower Seed Home Cultivation Kit?

X: That's right, Bellflower.

With his hands lifted high, X stretched lazily, as if he were a cat basking in the warmth of a sunny afternoon.

X: You can use these inconspicuous little grass seeds as bullets. They're light, and blunt enough.

X: They won't cut flesh or leave a gash, but they'll startle most animals just fine. Paired with the Air-Compressed Spring Slingshot's "thwack", they should scare off any critters you encounter.

Ezra: That's perfect—exactly what I need!

The kind-hearted boy practically bounced off the sofa with excitement, but then...

Ezra: Whoa—!

He tumbled back down.

Ezra: My head... I'm so dizzy...

X: It's a normal symptom.

X: The Red-Flower Prickly Pear juice, as an antidote, induces dizziness about three hours after consumption. They should've warned you about that when you picked them up from the Potionary Department.

X lifted the teapot, refilling Ezra's cup with piping hot tea.

X: Here, have some more tea. It'll make you feel better.

Ezra: Did you brew the tea because you knew I'd be dizzy?

X: To help ease the medicine's effects and to be a good host, two birds with one stone.

X: Still, I suggest you don't rush to leave.

X: I know you're tight on time, but rest is crucial. You can stay here until the dizziness subsides.

Ezra: I understand. I do need to rest.

Ezra: I'll stay here until my body recovers and I'm ready for my next climb.

Ezra cradled the teacup, the light brown liquid swaying within.

Ezra: Hm? This aroma...

Ezra: Is this Dryad Tea?

X: No, it's not. Although they both smell like melted snow, this is just a warming tea made with Croton Gratissimus and Ginger Sting.

X: If I could, I'd make Dryad Tea for you. A cup of that, and you'd be back on your feet in no time.

X: That way, you wouldn't have to languish here, chatting aimlessly with "researchers".

Ezra: Oh don't say that... I'm happy to talk with you.

Ezra struggled to get up from the sofa, but X softly nudged him back into the corner.

X: I was just joking, kid.

X: You know what "humor" is right? Well, scratch that; I should've known that humans lacked that talent.

Ezra: I know plenty of "jokes"... I'm just not good at telling them...

The boy murmured softly as he sipped his tea, huddled into the corner of the sofa.

Ezra: I asked my mom why once, she just said she's not good at telling jokes either.

Ezra: ...Even though my friends say stereotypes don't hold true, it feels like my whole family fits the bill. We're not exactly masters of humor.

X: Well, good humor is only a small part of life; it doesn't matter.

The arcanist said with a wave of his hand.

X: So you lack humor, but you have other strengths.

Ezra: You mean ...?

X: ——Stubbornness.

X blinked.

X: I'm not saying you lack skills, but from what I gather, you're incredibly determined.

X: You discussed your fantastical plan with Dr. Ryan, wrote out your proposal, and executed it meticulously—of course, all things a competent curator should do.

X: But beyond that, you turned down all of the help the Laplace Scientific Computing Center offered.

X: Take our current predicament, for instance, those beasts and birds of prey dwelling in the mountains.

X: If you wanted to handle things simply, Laplace's task force could clear your path with just three sets of tranquilizer darts.

Ezra: Sure, it might take some time for the task force to prepare an operational plan and acquire the necessary equipment.

X: And indeed, they'd need a little time, but they work fast and wouldn't hold up your journey.

X: Your real reason for refusing them isn't that.

Ezra: Right... I have to personally collect these specimens and climb that mountain under my own power.

Ezra: It's the centerpiece of the exhibition, the "thing" I must accomplish.

X: Hmm... So, you believe in hands-on experience when it comes to getting things done?

Ezra: Certainly, just as all naturalists must venture into nature.

Ezra: If you stay away from nature, nature stays away from you... that's what my teacher taught me, isn't... isn't that right?

X: No, it's absolutely right for you.

X: But the world isn't just made up of natural phenomena; there are other manifestations of wisdom as well.

X: Like the hand behind the scenes, manipulating the switches.

X: Look here.

X reached out, rubbing his thumb against his index finger, and a small golden bead appeared in his hand.

X: I could toss this bead, and it would collide between the teacup and the teapot.

X: After that, it would ricochet to the right, knocking down the upright book on the table, which, in turn, would tug on a fishing line, rotating the gas stove switch 75° in a room three doors down and starting to heat a pot of water.

X: As the water boils, the rising steam would melt the chocolate hanging on the cabinet, and the dominoes, now lighter, would tumble down the ventilation shaft to the sixth room downstairs.

Ezra: Downstairs, in the sixth room... that's...

X: Medicine Pocket's research lab.

Ezra: What would happen then?

X: The glass by the potted plants would tip over, spilling water into the soil, and the glass would shatter on the floor.

Ezra: ... All this just to water some plants?

X: Yes. Although it costs a glass, the potted flower won't wither from thirst.

The master of Rube Goldberg mechanics extended his hand, causing the golden bead in the center of his glove to sway before steadying.

X: Do you want to throw this bead?

Ezra: ... Me?

Ezra: I... I suppose not...

Ezra eyed the golden bead in bewilderment, as if it were a monumental choice.

He hesitated but still spoke up.

Ezra: If I need to water that flower, I can just go downstairs, pick up the glass, and pour water into it.

Ezra: ...That would save the glass.

X: Haha, don't worry; I'm not lecturing you on how to do things.

X: I'm just curious why you want to choose the most troublesome, most arduous paths.

X: Any researcher with hands-on experience would want to use our technology; we're all from Laplace after all, and no matter which branch, we stand at the intersection of technology and Arcane Skill, pursuing a great fusion.

X: No one in their right mind would refuse a ladder when climbing simply because it was his habit not to use technology.

Ezra: ……

Ezra closed his eyes, falling silent, then reopened them.

Ezra: Because this mountain is special to me.

Ezra: ...I first learned about it from my family's archives and the stories my mother used to tell me.

Ezra: You could say it's a childhood obsession, but either way, it's something I've longed for since I was a very, very little child.

X: Ah... childhood obsessions. A common theme.

The tilted teapot no longer poured fresh tea; it was light, as if there had been nothing left inside.

X: I knew a child just like you, he also loved the mountains. But unlike you, his yearning for them stems from his love of a particular flower: the white dryads.

X: Those small, white flowers with yellow pistils covered his childhood picture book, to him they represented almost every virtue imaginable.

X set down the teapot and stood up from the sofa.

X: Stand up and try your legs, Ezra. It's about time.

Ezra: Than-thank you.

Ezra: Mm-hmm... Yeah, you're right... The dizziness is gone! I think it's the hot tea. It really got me to sweat out all those toxins.

The boy stretched his body , feeling full of vitality again.

Ezra: I feel almost like I never poisoned myself—I think I could set off again right away.

X: I won't stop you; I'm not your doctor.

The arcanist opened the door as if releasing a bird about to take flight.

X: But if you have some free time, try to enjoy the scenery on the mountain for me.

X: Perhaps there are some lovely white dryads there, perhaps not, but it doesn't matter. Just go and take a look.

Medicine Pocket: So, you're just letting him off the hook like that?

X: I've told you, I'm not a doctor, it's not my job to look after his health.

X: Giving him some hot tea was about as considerate as could be expected of me.

Innocent as ever. X shrugged with a smile.

Medicine Pocket: That's not what I meant; he didn't water my plants, and you still haven't tossed that silly bead either—now I'll probably come back to a bunch of dead plants!

X: ……

X: That's not any of our responsibilities, Medicine Pocket.

X: If you want to keep plants, you've got to take care of them yourself, just like you do with your lab samples.

Medicine Pocket: Those plants aren't my lab samples.

Medicine Pocket: My current project isn't about pest control for plants—

Mesmer Jr.: Let's put an end to this pointless argument and talk about what happened next.

5#1

Old Acquaintance

COL-307305

Ezra returned to the Computing Center and headed straight for X's office.

X: Oh—it's you, you're back.

At that moment, X was busy trying to extract a gold tooth from a skull.

Focused as he was on the task at hand, he didn't bother to look up, but he didn't forget to ask.

X: Is my little contraption still doing the job?

Ezra: Perfectly! It's worked better than any slingshot I've used before. It didn't hurt any animals, but I managed to scare them away. It's really come in handy.

X: It's my pleasure, Director.

X: ...Hyah!

The gold tooth was finally dislodged and shot up high into the air.

Then it came down, slow and steady, landing in X's palm.

X: There, now I can actually focus and listen to what you have to say.

X: Hmm? What's this...

Ezra: I stumbled upon this Dryas octopetala ... er, white dryad on a cliff behind a beasts' den.

Ezra: It's not the typical season for Dryas octopetala to bloom, so I only spotted this one. To make sure it doesn't wither, I placed it along with its surrounding vegetation in my foraging box.

Ezra: Though when it was first placed in the box, it did show signs of withering.

Ezra: I was taken aback at first, but then I quickly realized I could solve the problem...

The gold tooth fell into a tin can, along with the gold bead, a die, and some crumpled paper.

X: It's beautiful, just as I imagined.

Ezra: You like it? Great!

Ezra: Please accept it as a gift, Mr. X.

X: ... For me?

X paused, silently pointing to himself with a questioning expression.

X: ...You're giving me the flower?

Ezra: Yes, I thought I might give it to you.

X: But what about your exhibition? The Dryas octopetala would make for a fantastic addition.

X: You climbed the mountain to find these plants, to present them in your exhibition—right?

Ezra: That's right, my task is to collect exotic plants from the mountain.

Ezra: But I picked the white dryads for you ...

Ezra: You generously helped me solve my problem, and this is my way of thanking you.

Ezra nodded, then nodded again.

Ezra: Of course, you could also give it to that kid you know—the one who's so fond of these flowers.

Ezra: I'm sure he'd be thrilled to see this flower; it might only be a small part of my exhibition, but for him, it'll mean a lot more.

X: ……

The handful of pure white flowers held in the child's hands were lifted up high.

He looked devout and sincere, almost like an angel. He just needed a white robe and a trumpet to complete the image.

X: Ezra, do you know what white dryads symbolize in the East?

Ezra: Symbolize?

Ezra: I've ever heard them referred to as the "flower of warmth and kindness"... is there another meaning behind them?

X: In the East, Dryas octopetala is associated with "health" and "longevity" because of their resilience in harsh environments and prolonged blooming seasons.

X: Among the arcanists who live near the mountains, there's a custom of braiding White Dryads into children's hair to ensure happiness and a long life.

X: ……

X reached out and took the Dryas octopetala from Ezra's hand.

X: I met that kid back in the orphanage.

X: I was 11 at the time, and he was 9.

Ezra: Oh... so it goes back to your past, from those days...

X: Now, I'm 16.

X: And ... He didn't get to be 10.

X: I have no need for this flower.

Mesmer Jr.: Remember when you said you wouldn't turn down his gift if you were in my shoes?

X: Our situation's a bit different. He's a good kid, I'll give you that. At first, I was testing him, but once I got to know him, I started to genuinely like him.

X: I want his exhibition to succeed, and honestly, I don't need that flower.

X glanced away toward the crowd gathering around the Dryas octopetala display.

X: See, a beauty like that flower deserves to be right here—under the spotlight, encased in that high-transparency glass. It'll wow everyone.

Mesmer Jr.: But your words probably hurt him.

X: ...I never meant to deceive him. But lying's easy, and I'm pretty well-versed in it.

X: But you know, I grew up in an orphanage, always surrounded by kids.

X: He is so young that I feel a pang of guilt looking into his eyes, yet mature enough to handle the truth.

Mesmer Jr.: ……

Mesmer Jr.: I would take that flower if I were you.

Mesmer Jr.: It's gorgeous, easy to care for, and it'd make both of you happy.

Mesmer Jr.: Plus, it could be a part of your complicated contraptions. Brewing Dryad tea with a dollop of butter beats regular tea any day.

X: Hey-hey! You can't expect such a kind-hearted lad to be so selfish, only focused on his research. I'm not that heartless of a scholar!

Medicine Pocket: Oh...

Medicine Pocket: Apparently I am.

Medicine Pocket: I heard you're heading to the snowy mountains. Got any room in your backpack?

The guest moved around as if it was a home from home, and the host didn't mind.

The door bounced off against the wall, still rattling as Medicine Pocket sank into the guest sofa.

Ezra: Sure, I'm leaving for the snowy mountains in twenty minutes. I could squeeze in an extra bag for you.

The young man flashed a grin as he packed, welcoming his friend officially.

Ezra: Welcome to my very own turf, Medicine Pocket.

Ezra: This is the first time we're meeting since I moved to HQ—I thought about saying hello earlier, but with the exhibition prep and handovers, I couldn't find the time.

Medicine Pocket: Don't sweat it. We're not the kind of phony friends who need to "catch up often" to stay close.

A hand popped up from behind the crest of the sofa, followed by a leg.

Medicine Pocket: I've got something more important than small talk.

Ezra: Sure thing, go ahead. I'm listening.

Medicine Pocket: I'm working on a project—top secret. You're the only one I'm telling, so keep it under wraps.

Medicine Pocket: I'm talking about human stamina supplements, sort of like "Picrasma Candy" for humans.

Medicine Pocket: Right now, we've hit a snag in our sourcing.

Medicine Pocket: And you, my friend ...

Now an excited head popped out from the sofa's edge.

Medicine Pocket: Your snowy mountain trip could be a big help.

Medicine Pocket: Remember why I went to Australia?

Ezra: Of course, I was the one who told you to head to the Croc n' Roll bookstore to hunt down a fragment of the Potion Analysis Handbook.

Medicine Pocket: Great memory. Keep working that brain; it's good for avoiding dementia—

Medicine Pocket: I've been studying those fragments since I got back from Australia, and I managed to recover the formula for one of the potions.

Ezra: The first one? Or the one about mushrooms on page twenty-three—

Medicine Pocket: Neither, it's right at the end. The page is a mess, but it contains a recipe for "Bone-melting Sacramental Wine" given by the priests.

Medicine Pocket: Those who drink it at night, with eyes shining like stars, struggle to hold it down, vomiting until they're nothing more than bones.

Medicine Pocket: But those who drink it during the day, with fingertips glowing and hot, can walk for miles on end and gain boundless strength.

Ezra: So... you figure the "night people" are arcanists, and the "day people" are regular folks?

Ezra: Hmm, is this... a restorative potion crafted specifically for humans?

Medicine Pocket: It looks like it, especially if you consider the local culture and the history of arcanism. The moon, night, tides—all that "yin" stuff usually associated with emotions, inspiration, and omens, which are definitely part of the Arcanists.

Medicine Pocket: And in contrast, the sun and daylight lean towards "yang," representing that which is guided by light, righteousness, reason.

Medicine Pocket: Although sun worship is present in arcane cultures, at times, it's used to describe regular folks when contrasted with the moon.

Ezra: But if this potion really is toxic to arcanists or whoever else, we have to tread carefully.

Ezra mulled it over for a few seconds.

Ezra: That's just a sensible guess; we'll need solid proof.

Medicine Pocket: Good, the spirit of scientific inquiry. I like it.

Medicine Pocket rolled off the beanbag sofa, lying on the floor. With a push from their legs, they sat up.

They pulled out a wrinkled piece of paper from their pocket, which looked like a page from a book.

Medicine Pocket: That's why I came to you and why I think I'm onto something.

Ezra: Is this Pinguicula alpina?

Alpine butterwort every potion maker knows it; far from just your regular flower or herb.

Ezra: So it's needed for the formula you recovered?

Medicine Pocket: Yes! That's right.

Medicine Pocket: The legendary ingredient, untouchable by arcanists, is a most elusive plant, found on the highest peaks of the Alps.

Ezra: ...Huh.

Ezra: Certainly, if the recipe includes Pinguicula alpina, that explains the potion's restorative effects.

Ezra: Almost all arcanists react badly to it due to neuron secretions...

Ezra: Common symptoms include itchy skin, vomiting, and phantom pains that feel like "breaking bones."

Medicine Pocket: I get what you're saying.

Ezra: You... need me to pick some Pinguicula alpina for you since I'm human and won't keel over?

Medicine Pocket: Bingo!

Medicine Pocket: Of course, there are other reasons, like only your exhibition authorization can bypass safety protocols to get it to my lab pronto...

Ezra: My... Exhibition authorization?

Medicine Pocket: Forget it; there's nothing to worry about!

Medicine Pocket: You're just helping me out, okay? So when those old farts come asking questions, you're in the clear.

Ezra: ...Is that something I should worry about?

Medicine Pocket: Oh, Ezra!

The young "mad" scientist stood up, brushing off imaginary dust from their thighs, warmly embracing Ezra.

The kid wobbled into the hug before finding himself pushed toward the door.

Medicine Pocket: I'll handle everything, alright?

Medicine Pocket: Just grab that darn grass—pluck it, stuff it in a box, and bring it to me!

5#1

One Who Stole Fire

COL-307306

Ezra: As per the itinerary, it was supposed to be my final trek up the mountain.

Ezra: I'd locate my most crucial specimens and procure the ingredient for the potion my friend needed.

Ezra: ……

Ezra: However, things didn't go quite so smoothly.

Ezra: …I need to request permission to continue my ascent.

Ezra: If I can't find it at 2,000 meters, I'll keep climbing to 3,000 meters, maybe even 3,200 meters.

Ezra: I must find it. Please, allow me to look.

Ezra: ……

Ezra: Yes, ma'am. I understand the risks, but I'll devise a more detailed plan. Trust me—

Ezra: ……

Medicine Pocket: Looks like I've come at a bad time …

The observer finally spoke, having waited by the door for quite a while.

Ezra: …No, it's nothing. Come in, Medicine Pocket.

The office's young inhabitant gestured, and Medicine Pocket entered, shutting the door behind them.

Medicine Pocket: Your preparations didn't go well, huh? I heard you didn't find what you needed on the mountain.

Medicine Pocket: And my ingredient? Did you find it?

Ezra: Yes, it's right here.

Ezra placed a sealed acrylic box on the table, containing the Pinguicula alpina inside.

Medicine Pocket: Great—at least we've got some good news!

Medicine Pocket: I brought gloves. Let me just check…

Medicine Pocket placed a large white box beside the acrylic one and slipped on a pair of plastic gloves over their own pair

Medicine Pocket: That ought to do it.

Ezra: Medicine Pocket, is this box… your field toolkit?

Medicine Pocket: Yep, your room's mine now. I'll be doing my experiments here.

Test tubes, stirring rods, and a recorder cluttered Ezra's desk.

The uninvited guest pulled over a chair and began their experiment as if they owned the place.

Ezra: So you're here to talk me out of it too?

Ezra lowered his head, fingers intertwined.

Ezra: I know it's risky and maybe irrational—I faced opposition from the start… but…

Medicine Pocket: Hold on.

Medicine Pocket: Now, think hard—have you ever needed to caution me, even once?

The dilution flowed from one test tube to another, dividing evenly.

Medicine Pocket: If you aren't a boring lecturer with a rusty old brain, then —I— as your friend, certainly am not that kind of person.

Medicine Pocket: I've gotten many things from you, all incredibly dangerous...

Medicine Pocket: But you handed them over because you knew mad as I am I'm a sensible "madman," and I would never throw away my life, no matter how much of my "health" I risk doing these experiments.

Medicine Pocket: You know I'm taking risks, and you're taking them too.

Ezra: You're right, Medicine Pocket.

Ezra: Sorry, I gotta interrupt you. Why the syringe?

Medicine Pocket: Ah?

Expelling air from the syringe, the scientist looked up, mouth open, in a questioning expression.

Medicine Pocket: Come on... I just said you've never cautioned me, and now you're telling me to be careful?

Ezra: No, I mean—this reagent isn't safe to inject.

Ezra: I saw you added Pinguicula alpina to the dilution; it'll could cause an allergic reaction.

Medicine Pocket: Oh—right, I forgot to tell you.

Rolling up their sleeve, they exposed their own arm.

Medicine Pocket located a vein and skillfully administered the injection.

Medicine Pocket: Phew... My moral compass doesn't allow for a medicine "beneficial to some but toxic to others." and genius that I am, I've improved the formula.

Ezra stood, went around, and adjusted the chair for their friend.

Ezra: Don't move, just relax.

Ezra: Here, put your feet up on my desk.

Medicine Pocket: It's... fine... just a bit dizzy. My mind's clear—you can continue... talking...

The young scientist squinted, rocking their chair.

They still remembered that this conversation wasn't just about Pinguicula alpina.

Ezra: Remember the past? When we first met.

Ezra brought a chair and sat beside Medicine Pocket.

Ezra: Back then, you told me about your family.

Ezra: About the story your mother used to tell you.

Medicine Pocket: Hmm? Oh... that story...

Medicine Pocket: Was that... the story about the snow-capped mountains?

Ezra: Yeah, that's the one.

Ezra: A tale about a climber and the stars up on those snowy peaks.

Ezra: I remember the main character, always climbing just to find a star and bring it down to heal all the world's woes.

Ezra: But the mountains were so high, the snow so deep; the freezing peaks knocked him down time and again.

Ezra: He tumbled down into the snow countless times, until he eventually looked like a snowman.

Medicine Pocket: Ah... a tragic tale, kind of like Prometheus stealing fire...

Medicine Pocket coughed under their breath, their words coming slower.

Medicine Pocket: But the climber made it in the end. The star fell down to the people, and all the pain and suffering disappeared... but he, well...

Medicine Pocket: ended up a... nothing more than a snowman...

Ezra: .....

Ezra: But he succeeded, and the star wasn't out of reach anymore... it belonged to the people.

Ezra: I love that story; it's just so heartwarming and touching.

Ezra: And I mentioned my family and my parents, right?

Ezra: But what I failed to mention was... Once, I stumbled upon a hefty book tucked away on the highest shelf in my house.

Ezra: It was... our family history.

Ezra: In it, I saw myself, my folks, grandparents, and faces I'd never laid eyes on... my great-grandfolks, even older generations and distant family I never knew.

Ezra: Until... on the last page...

Ezra: Surrounded by white flowers, a tiny figure was scarcely visible.

Ezra: They were Leontopodium nivale, also known as Edelweiss.

Ezra: It grew up there on the snowy peak, blending in almost perfectly.

Ezra: I know it, it is called the Alps.

Medicine Pocket: Oh... well, now I get why you're so fixated on it...

Ezra: .....

Ezra: "It is a place more distant than the farthest north, situated on a mountain where humans and arcanists coexist. In this place, there is no unrighteous conflict or death."

Ezra: A perfect world.

Ezra: No conflicts, no struggles, no deceit, no pride, no hate ... not like down here.

Ezra's hands clasped together.

His voice was like a snowflake drifting down onto heavy snow.

Ezra: It's... my dream.

Ezra: But it's a miracle, one that feels so far out of reach.

Medicine Pocket's chest rose and fell, their breath steady but drawn out.

Ezra: But I'm not the same anymore. I've seen how flames ignite and how miracles unfold.

Ezra: I think I can chase miracles too... I can make the "impossible" possible.

The boy, still brimming with youth, whispered to himself, his sleeping friend's head tilted to the side. Across from him, on the table, two test tubes sat side by side.

One empty, the other full. An unopened syringe lay quietly beside the full one.

Ezra: I'll... climb those towering peaks.

It was as if a door had been opened.

Ezra: ...I'll, pluck down those sparkling stars.

5#1

Above the Snow

COL-307307

Medicine Pocket: That's the last thing I remember clearly.

Medicine Pocket: After that, my consciousness, like young Ezra, became a snowflake lost in the mountains—vanished without a trace.

Medicine Pocket shrugged helplessly, palms open.

Mesmer Jr.: Let it go. You left him a vial of the potion; your message was clear enough.

Mesmer Jr.: When you woke up—what about the test tube? Was it still there?

Medicine Pocket: Of course not; Ezra isn't that naive.

Medicine Pocket: He lost Laplace's approval, which means he's without their technical support and backing. If he wanted to return to that mountain and climb higher and farther, he'd have to rely on my potion.

Mesmer Jr.: You're pushing him into a dangerous situation.

The young woman lowered her head, fidgeting with the cuffs of her uniform as if the fabric was itching her skin.

Mesmer Jr.: You're his friend. You shouldn't—

Medicine Pocket: As friends, it's only right that I help him, anyway I can.

Medicine Pocket: He'd do the same for me.

X: ...From what I know, earlier today, an emergency team was sent to the mountain.

Mesmer Jr.: What? To find Ezra?

X: I think so. But it wasn't Ezra who requested help.

X: ……

Medicine Pocket: Why are you looking at me like that? He hasn't come back all night; it's about time to send someone to fetch him!

Medicine Pocket: My potion can sustain him wandering around the mountain until he finds that damn Edelweiss, but it's still an experimental drug. If he climbs too high, he might lose strength before he reaches the peak.

The Girl: Wow—look over there! The lady is back!

The child's exclamation interrupted the Laplace staff, and people in the exhibition hall turned to look as the assistant curator wheeled a cart toward the center of the hall.

Mesmer Jr.: What's that?

The young woman straightened up, fixing the microphone dangling from her cheek.

Assistant Curator: First, I must apologize to all our attendees. I'm afraid Director Ezra's speech has been canceled.

Assistant Curator: Our new director is currently undergoing treatment at Laplace Hospital and unfortunately, can't meet with you all at this time.

Assistant Curator: However, Director Ezra still brings us an unparalleled piece of good news.

A smile spread across her face.

The black velvet covering the cage was pulled off, revealing the square outline of the terrarium underneath.

Mesmer Jr.: Is that... Ezra's mushroom terrarium?

Medicine Pocket: Ha! That's the Leontopodium alpinum!

Laplace Staff I: Oh my god! I heard he was looking for it, but I didn't think he could actually find it—!

Laplace Staff II: Until now, no indoor exhibition has successfully displayed a live Leontopodium alpinum. Even the World Plant Exhibition held by the St. Pavlov Foundation only exhibited a preserved specimen!

Laplace Staff II: Academics once believed it couldn't leave the mountain ... Am I dreaming...?

The audience erupted in awe, the sounds blending into a wave of excitement.

People who had been lingering in front of various exhibits began to gather in the center of the exhibition hall.

No one wanted to miss witnessing a miracle.

The Girl: Hmm...? What's that card?

X: It's an introductory note, my dear.

X bent down to shield the girl from being jostled by the crowd.

X: Judging by the style, it feels like my friend penned this, the very person who found this plant, the curator behind this exhibition.

The Girl: Ah, I know him! My grandfather told me about him!

The little girl made a mushroom shape with her hands on her head.

The Girl: He sometimes wears a hat—a mushroom-shaped hat. I remember his hat!

The Girl: I haven't talked to him yet, but I've always wanted to...

X: Maybe you can start by reading what he's written. It's right here.

It was a paper note, placed next to the terrarium.

It had been soaked by snowmelt and then dried, slightly grayish in color, contrasting with the snowy white flowers, like its dark shadow.

X and the girl picked it up, and only then did people begin to notice it.

Ezra: "Leontopodium alpinum, also known as Edelweiss, is a plant from the Leontopodium genus, Asteraceae family."

Ezra: "Unlike other Leontopodium species, it mainly grows in high-altitude plateaus and mountainous regions, ranging from 3000 to 3800 meters above sea level."

Ezra: "It's highly flammable, making it an excellent kindling material, which is why it's known as the 'fiery grass'."

Ezra: "At the same time, its snowflake-like white color earned it the nickname 'snowdrop flower'."

Ezra: "My mother introduced me to this flower; she told me that, in my hometown, it is a symbol of peace, stability, and genuine understanding."

Ezra: "Legend has it in the snowy territories that this blossom belonged to a fabled kingdom, unseen and shrouded in perfection."

Ezra: "In that kingdom, there is no conflict. People love each other, respect each other, and treat each other equally."

Ezra: "And the Edelweiss was the emissary of that kingdom, entering our world through cracks in the window sill. Where the Edelweiss grew was on the borderland next to this ideal kingdom."

Ezra: "The origin of the legend is uncertain, and the existence of such an 'unknown and unseen kingdom' is yet to be proven."

Ezra: "But undoubtedly, upon the Edelweiss rests the people's sincere hopes for peace, mutual understanding, love, and respect."

Ezra: "And this, truly, is the theme of this exhibition."

Ezra: "Those with eyes can behold the beauty of its flowers; those with hands can touch the greenery of its stems."

Ezra: "Those with blood flowing through their veins can walk; those with beating hearts can love each other."

Ezra: "From today, from this moment."

Ezra: The ideal kingdom will border the soil beneath the snow-capped mountains. One single spark on the edelweiss will spread and light up the sky.

5#2